

Rocks and minerals

The Earth's crust is made up of different rocks. Some of these are hard but others are soft and crumbly. They are formed in different ways.

What is a rock?

A rock is formed from minerals. Most rocks are made up of different minerals, but some contain just one. There are three main types of rock: igneous, sedimentary, and metamorphic.

The rock cycle

Over many years, the rocks in the Earth's crust gradually change from one type into another. They are transformed by wind, water, pressure, and heat.

Sedimentary rock

Wind and water wear rocks away. Small pieces wash into the sea. These settle into layers, which pack together to form sedimentary rocks, such as limestone and sandstone.



Igneous rock

When hot molten magma from the Earth's interior cools and solidifies, it forms igneous rocks. Some harden underground, such as granite. Some erupt first as lava in a volcano.



Metamorphic rock

Sometimes rocks are crushed underground, or scorched by hot magma. Then they may be transformed into new rocks, such as marble, slate, and gneiss.



Serpentine is a mineral that stone carvers use to create works of art.



Gabbro is a rock that is used to make kitchen surfaces and floors.



White mica is a mineral that you can find in some kinds of toothpaste.

Fossils in stones

Fossils are the remains or imprints of plants and animals that died millions of years ago, preserved in stone.

